

CIRCULATION IN THE UTERUS

As the placenta provides oxygen and nutrients, the fetal circulation has anatomical variations (“shunts”) that bypass the not-yet-functioning liver and lungs. The ductus venosus shunts incoming blood through the liver to the right atrium, which shunts it through a gap, the

foramen ovale, to the left atrium (mostly bypassing the right ventricle) and onward to the body. Any blood that enters the right ventricle passes into the pulmonary artery but is shunted into the aorta by the ductus arteriosus, thus bypassing the lungs.

